WEB3NOVA • LEARN, BUILD AND EARN

UI/UX Introductory Class

Learn the language, see the invisible work in everyday products, and redesign your first real workflow.

Learn, Build and Earn

FOUNDATION TRACK • WEB3NOVA



OBSERVATION • EVERYDAY PATTERNS

Good design disappears into the task

When software works seamlessly, you notice your goal. When it breaks, you notice the tool.

WHATSAPP & MESSAGING

Instant feedback loops

Delivered checkmarks and typing indicators remove cognitive friction. You never ask if your message went through.

GOOGLE MAPS & UBER

Real-time spatial context

A live car icon moving on a street map replaces anxiety with certainty, keeping riders grounded in time and location.

SPOTIFY AUDIO

Frictionless continuation

A single persistent green play button keeps controls predictable across phones, tablets, and desktop apps.

UNIVERSITY PORTAL

The sudden roadblock

Course registration stalls with expired sessions, obscure course codes, and missing confirmations. Why does it feel so hard?

Key Question: What made your last digital task feel effortless, and what made you feel stuck?

CORE DEFINITIONS • THE TWO SIDES OF PRODUCT DESIGN

UI is what people see. UX is what people go through.

Examining both through one everyday action: booking a ride on a rainy evening.

USER INTERFACE (UI)

The visual surface

The tangible aesthetic elements on screen:

- **Typography & Scale:** Readable fares and arrival times
- **Color & Contrast:** High-contrast black confirm button
- **Map Rendering:** Pins, street labels, and route geometry
- **Iconography:** Car silhouettes, luggage badges, ratings
- **Motion:** Smooth sheet transitions sliding into view

USER EXPERIENCE (UX)

The human journey

How the system feels and performs across time:

- **Certainty:** Exact upfront fare before clicking
- **Speed:** Driver matched within 8 seconds of request
- **Error Recovery:** Move pickup pin 20 meters effortlessly
- **Peace of Mind:** Share a live trip status link with a friend
- **Sense of Control:** Clear cancellation policy, no surprises

The Rule: UI is how the car looks on the map; UX is knowing your driver is 3 minutes away while you wait in the cold.

CRITICAL CONTRAST • SURFACE VS SUBSTANCE

One product can look polished and still feel difficult

Visual design is only one layer. Without clear flow logic, beauty becomes friction.

FRUSTRATING CHECKOUT FLOW

Polished but Obstructed

Looks modern with gradients and animations, but:

- Forces mandatory account creation before price total
- Hidden shipping fees appear on the final payment screen
- Unclear error: *"Invalid input"* with no field highlighted
- Resets entire credit card form on a single mistake

Outcome: 68% cart abandonment and buyer anxiety

SEAMLESS CHECKOUT FLOW

Clear and Transparent

Prioritizes user confidence and effortless completion:

- One-tap guest checkout with auto-filled postal address
- Upfront total with all delivery options visible early
- Inline validation explaining: *"Phone needs 10 digits"*
- Preserves form state while correcting mistakes

Outcome: Fast completion, high trust, zero confusion

The Lesson: Never use aesthetics to disguise poor architecture. Usability builds true brand loyalty.

FOUNDATIONS • THE 5 HEURISTICS

Five qualities of usable products

Master these five principles to evaluate any interface in minutes.

1. Clarity: **Users immediately know what to do next.** Plain language replaces jargon; primary buttons use explicit action verbs.

2. Hierarchy: **Important actions dominate attention.** Size, contrast, and spacing guide the eye naturally before body text is read.

3. Consistency: **Repeated patterns behave the exact same way.** Navigation, icons, and gestures stay predictable across screens.

4. Feedback: **The system responds to every human action.** Loading spinners, success toasts, and error notices keep the user informed.

5. Accessibility: **More people can succeed in more contexts.** High color contrast, generous touch targets, and full keyboard control.

CHECKLIST: Test any student portal or app against these 5 qualities to immediately spot user drop-off points.

DESIGN METHODOLOGY • THE ITERATIVE CYCLE

Design is a loop, not a straight line

Great products aren't designed in one stroke. Evidence feeds the next iteration.

PHASE 01

Understand People

Observe students in their actual environment; find hidden constraints.

PHASE 02

Define the Problem

Reframe symptoms into real root causes instead of superficial fixes.

PHASE 03

Sketch & Structure

Draw low-fidelity paper wireframes to map user journeys rapidly.

PHASE 04

Prototype

Create interactive Figma links with clickable buttons and mock states.

PHASE 05

Test with Users

Watch five people try the task without giving them hints or coaching.

PHASE 06

Iterate & Refine

Change what caused confusion and loop back to Phase 3 with proof.

Key Takeaway for Designers: You are not designing to prove your first guess was right. You are designing to discover what works through evidence.

Testing with just 5 real users uncovers 85% of usability bottlenecks before building production code.

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CAMPUS CASE STUDY • FLOW BREAKDOWN

Case study: fixing a university registration flow

Mapping student friction across five registration stages and how to fix them.

Step 1 · Course Discovery: Students face cryptic department codes like *"ENG-304B"* with no schedule preview. **Fix:** Clear course titles, professor ratings, and syllabus highlights.

Step 2 · Timetable Selection: Clashing lecture slots only error out after 12 clicks. **Fix:** Interactive weekly timetable view showing live conflict warnings as you click.

Step 3 · Prerequisite Check: Generic failure: *"Prerequisites not met"* without naming the missing credit. **Fix:** Explicit message stating: *"Requires CS-101 (Completed 2025)"* with advisor contact.

Step 4 · Progress Stepper: No visible progress bar; students wonder how many screens remain before session timeout. **Fix:** Clear 3-step numbered progress bar with persistent draft saving.

Step 5 · Confirmation: Screen reloads to home page without receipt or calendar sync. **Fix:** Green checkmark, downloadable PDF confirmation, and one-click calendar export.

The Impact: Small UX changes cut IT support tickets by 60% and eliminate student start-of-semester panic.

UNIVERSAL ACCESSIBILITY • BEYOND THE "AVERAGE" USER

Inclusive design is part of good design

Designing for edge cases creates products that work significantly better for everyone.

CONTRAST & READABILITY

High Visual Contrast

Avoid faint gray-on-white text. High-contrast type helps students with visual impairments as well as anyone using their phone under bright midday sun.

TOUCH TARGETS & SPACING

Generous Click Areas

Minimum 48×48px tap targets prevent misclicks on mobile. Essential for motor tremors and for anyone walking with a coffee in one hand.

KEYBOARD & SCREEN READERS

Logical Focus Order

Every action must be reachable using only the Tab key and screen readers. Clear semantic HTML tags power assistant software reliably.

PLAIN LANGUAGE & SAFETY

Forgiving Recovery

Replace cryptic server codes with human explanations and simple *"Undo"* options. Reduces anxiety for second-language speakers and first-year students.

Critique Question: Who might be accidentally excluded by what your team considers a "normal" design?

DESIGN ARTIFACTS • FIDELITY SPECTRUM

From wireframe to prototype

Understand what each artifact solves before spending time perfecting visuals.

01 The Skeleton

Low-fidelity gray boxes and lines. Focuses on layout, content priority, and flow structure. Fast to discard and easy to reshape.

Solves: *"What belongs on this screen?"*

02 The Visual Skin

High-fidelity typography, colors, component states, and exact spacing. Applies brand identity and emotional feel to the skeleton.

Solves: *"How does the interface look & feel?"*

03 The Living Simulation

Connected, interactive clickable screens. Simulates real transitions, user actions, delays, and edge-case error flows.

Solves: *"How does the product behave?"*

Figma in Professional Practice: Figma is not an illustration app for making pictures. It is a shared canvas to think, test assumptions, and communicate decisions.

Experienced product designers sketch dozens of rough flows before touching polished visual components.

HANDS-ON STUDIO • PRACTICAL EXERCISE

Your first design challenge

Pick one frustrating digital task from student life and sketch an improved solution.

STEP 01

Name the User & Task

Select a real campus workflow: library room booking, printing credits, hostel check-in, or course drop-add. Define who is trying to do what.

STEP 02

Isolate the Friction Point

Where does the system break trust? Identify unclear labels, unnecessary steps, confusing buttons, or missing confirmations.

STEP 03

Sketch the Redesign

Draw 1–2 wireframe screens on paper or in Figma. Apply clear hierarchy: prominent primary action, obvious feedback, and plain language.

STEP 04

Plan the User Test

Write one prompt to test with a classmate: *"Try booking Room 4B for Thursday at 3 PM without my help."* Note where they hesitate.

Deliverable: 15 minutes to sketch, followed by 2-minute peer reviews. Focus on making the task obvious, not fancy.

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